

The Planning Fallacy

What is it?

People naturally focus on the best-case scenario and ignore possible delays or complications.

People tend to underestimate how long something will take, even when past experiences prove them wrong.

For example, you might think setting up an app will take just a minute or two—but ten minutes later, you're still answering questions.

History

The Planning Fallacy was first introduced in **1979** by psychologists **Daniel Kahneman** and **Amos Tversky**.

Their studies revealed that humans consistently underestimate time, costs, and risks, while overestimating their own abilities and efficiency—a form of optimistic bias that distorts planning accuracy.

The Psychology Behind It

Humans are naturally optimistic thinkers.

When faced with a new task, our brains prefer ideal expectations, focusing on best-case scenarios while ignoring possible obstacles or delays.

This creates a gap between **perceived** and **actual** effort, often leading to missed deadlines and frustration.

In UX, this bias can cause users to underestimate task completion times—resulting in dissatisfaction or abandonment when reality doesn't match expectation.

Why It Matters

- Increases customer frustration
 - Leads to task abandonment
 - Reduces user satisfaction
 - Damages trust and perceived ease of use
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How to Apply It

- **Set clear expectations** – Eg: “This form takes 2 minutes to complete.”
 - **Break tasks into smaller steps** – Eg: Multi-step onboarding or progress bars.
 - **Provide visible progress feedback** – Eg: “You’re halfway done.”
 - **Test real-time completion data** – Eg: Use analytics to match user perception vs. actual duration.
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Theory in Action

- **Medium** shows the estimated reading time at the top of each article, helping users plan realistically before they start reading.
 - **Disney** theme parks display *Wait Time Boards*, setting accurate expectations and reducing perceived waiting frustration.
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Final Thought

People will always believe they can get things done faster than reality allows.

Designs that acknowledge this bias—by setting accurate expectations and breaking complex actions into smaller wins—help users stay engaged and satisfied.